

In the ensuing five years, various factors served to increase this value. By 1961, the art objects for which the couple had paid \$650 were worth \$2000.

Now, none of these people are art experts. Their knowledge of art is limited to what they have picked up on their own by reading, visiting galleries and exhibitions and browsing in art and antique shops. To them, art collecting is simply a very pleasant extracurricular interest, a hobby if you prefer. They enjoy having objects around them that they consider aesthetically satisfying. They find it makes their lives more pleasurable.

The fundamentals of art collecting are not difficult to master. Obviously, the average person is not financially able to go on a shopping spree for Rembrandts, Fragonards, Gauguins or other paintings that—when and if available—

run into the hundreds of thousands or even millions of dollars.

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But even the individual who has only a very few hundred dollars to spend can buy good works of art—objects that are of high quality and that will retain or increase their value.

It stands to reason that the safest way to buy art is to employ an expert to do the buying—or to buy only in the most reputable galleries. But, by so doing, one will be paying the peak current market prices. Also, most people do not have the budgets to buy on the scale such purchasing implies—and many people would rather savor the adventure of shopping for works of art on their own.

However he does it, to buy art wisely, an individual must first make up his mind about what mediums and periods please him the most. He should then learn something—the more the better—about them. There are copies and counterfeits galore on the market—and the only way to distinguish between them and the genuine is by knowing which is which. (Reputable dealers will, of course, almost always permit the prospective buyer the right to have a piece authenticated, or will provide authoritative authentication themselves.)